Three First Moves for Seeing Who Mom's Week Depends On

Three things to write down, in order, and what can wait.

Mom is doing well at home. A neighbor drives her to appointments, your brother handles the bills, and you call every evening. It works, and nobody has ever written down how.

There's no clock on this. One evening and a sheet of paper are enough for a start. Three things, in this order.

1 Write down who does what, and who else could

List everyone who helps Mom and what each one does, the small things included: the ride to the doctor, the bills, the phone call every evening. Beside each task, write who else could do it. Where you can't name anyone, write “only them.” Where you don't know, write “not sure.” [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The other two moves both start from this list.

2 Ask about one backup

Pick one task, and think of the person the family would name if the usual helper couldn't do it. Ask that person whether they'd be willing, and write down what they say, with the date. Until someone has asked, the entry beside their name is “assumed.” [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST One conversation turns a guess into an answer, whichever answer it is.

3 Note what would bring you back to the list

At the bottom of the page, write the ordinary changes that would mean the list needs redoing: a helper's schedule changes, someone moves, Mom's health or medicines change. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often when health or medicines change, so put a date on the page as well. [3] [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A list of today is only useful while it's still true, and this is how the family will know when to redraw it.

What can wait

- Filling every blank. “Not sure” is a fair entry for now.
- Asking every backup. One conversation is a start, and the others can follow at the family's pace.
- What might be needed someday. Keep “not covered today” and “might come up later” as two separate notes, and let the second one stay short.
- Whether Mom's arrangement is enough, or whether anything about it should change. A list can't answer that. It's a conversation for Mom and the professionals who know her, and your page is what you'll bring to it.

Do this with Mom, not about her

It's her week on the page. The CDC's guide to care plans says to begin the conversation with the person herself, so show her the list and ask what she'd add, correct or take off.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Mom's arrangement is enough, predict what she'll need, or suggest changing anything. It puts three first notes in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down who does what, asked about one backup, and noted what would bring you back to the page. The care interview takes it from there: it walks through each area of Mom's daily life, including the parts that are fine today, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Listing who is responsible for which tasks, and asking who else can step in, follows the National Institute on Aging. Asking a likely helper about their willingness follows the Family Caregiver Alliance. Starting with the person herself, and updating a written plan yearly or when health or medicines change, follows the CDC. The order is ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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